

2026 BIG 12 CONFERENCE PRIMER

BIG 12 CONFERENCE

Conference outlook, tiers, projected order,
schedule inflection points and team directory.

WHAT DEFINES THE 2026 BIG 12?

One clear conference benchmark.

A wide, competitive chase pack.

Schedule distribution can reshape the standings.

Independent publication. Not affiliated with or endorsed by the Big 12 Conference.

BIG 12 AT A GLANCE

2026 CONFERENCE OVERVIEW

16 teams - 2026 preseason outlook

How to read the rankings: The **Primer power rating** estimates neutral-field team quality in points above or below an average FBS team. **Expected wins** is schedule-aware and reflects the full 12-game path. Those are intentionally different measures: a team can be stronger than another team while still projecting for fewer wins.

1. 60-Second Big 12 Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good is the Big 12?	Texas Tech is the one team that clearly separates from the field, while almost everything behind the Red Raiders is compressed enough for schedule and one swing unit to move teams several standings places. The league has one top-10 profile, one clear top-25 challenger and a broad group of credible eight-win teams.
Title favorite	Texas Tech. The Red Raiders lead the Big 12 at +22.0 in Primer power and 10.6 expected wins , with the strongest roster, the best model profile and a schedule that avoids several of the league's other top teams.
Best challenger	BYU. The Cougars sit at +15.0 with 8.8 expected wins and have the league's safest challenger floor because Bear Bachmeier, LJ Martin and a veteran defensive core provide unusually strong continuity.
Best outside-crasher profiles	Utah, Arizona, Kansas State and TCU. All four sit between +9.0 and +10.0 in power. Utah and Arizona have established quarterbacks, Kansas State owns the friendliest record path of the group, and TCU has enough front-seven quality to survive a major offensive transition.
Biggest league-wide storyline	The middle is extremely compressed. Houston, Oklahoma State, Arizona State, Baylor, Kansas, Cincinnati and UCF all have plausible bowl-or-better paths, but each carries a different QB, OL, defensive or implementation risk.
Schedule team to remember	Kansas State. The Wildcats rank only sixth in Big 12 underlying power at +9.0 but third in expected wins at 8.1 , aided by SP+ SOS No. 69 and a slate without a top-30 SP+ opponent.

Conference identity: The Big 12 is less about a deep stack of national-title rosters than about one clear favorite sitting above a wide band of competitive teams. Texas Tech has enough separation to be the preseason benchmark. BYU has the safest challenger floor. After that, Utah, Arizona, Kansas State, TCU and Houston are close enough that quarterback translation, offensive-line cohesion and schedule distribution matter as much as raw roster ranking. The lower half is similarly compressed: a team can move from projected 12th to seventh with one functional offensive line or one defense that overperforms its baseline.

Bottom line: **Texas Tech should be judged against championship expectations; almost everyone else should be judged against the Big 12's unusually thin margins.** The conference is built to produce standings surprises because team quality is clustered and the schedule does not distribute the hardest opponents evenly.

Five things to remember

- 1 Texas Tech is the clear preseason benchmark.** The Red Raiders are No. 1 in Big 12 power and expected wins, and their schedule avoids BYU, Utah and Kansas State.
- 2 BYU is the safest challenger.** Bear Bachmeier, LJ Martin and a defense returning 69% of production give the Cougars a more stable floor than most teams trying to replace multiple core units.
- 3 The next four teams are genuinely close.** Utah, Arizona, TCU and Kansas State sit within one point of one another in Primer power, but their schedule paths and roster risks are very different.
- 4 Quarterback certainty is a major separator.** BYU, Utah, Arizona, Kansas State and Houston return established starters; Arizona State, Kansas and West Virginia still carry open competitions, while TCU asks Jaden Craig to translate from Harvard.
- 5 The lower half is not far from the middle.** Baylor, Kansas, Cincinnati, UCF, Colorado, Iowa State and West Virginia all have identifiable strengths, but each needs at least one unsettled unit to become functional quickly.

2. Conference Power Structure

Tier	Teams	Read
Championship Tier	Texas Tech	The league's only top-10 model profile, with an experienced OL, premium skill talent and the most favorable schedule of any contender. The main risk is replacing QB Behren Morton and a large NFL-bound defensive class.
Contender Tier	BYU	The Cougars have a top-25 foundation at QB, RB and defense. Receiver, OL and specialist turnover reduce the ceiling, but the floor is unusually sturdy.
Outside Crashers	Utah, Arizona, Kansas State, TCU	Each is good enough to reach Arlington. Utah and Arizona have veteran quarterbacks, Kansas State has schedule leverage, and TCU has a stable defensive front but more offensive implementation risk.
Dangerous Middle	Houston, Oklahoma State, Arizona State, Baylor, Kansas, Cincinnati, UCF	This group is separated by only a few points of underlying quality. Houston is the most proven recent winner; Oklahoma State has the largest translation bet; the rest live near the bowl line with one major structural question apiece.
Bottom of the Table	Colorado, Iowa State, West Virginia	All three have credible offensive anchors and real bowl paths, but line play, low continuity or defensive replacement burden leaves less margin than the teams above them.

The Big 12's defining gap is at the very top. **Texas Tech is seven points clear of BYU and at least 12 points clear of every other team in the Primer power ratings.** Behind the Red Raiders, however, the conference tightens dramatically. Utah through Houston span only 2.5 points of power, and the middle from Oklahoma State through Cincinnati is close enough that coaching implementation and schedule location can decide several standings places.

3. Projected Conference Order

This is a schedule-aware projected order, anchored by expected overall wins and then adjusted editorially for team quality and uncertainty. It is not the underlying Big 12 power ranking.

Rank	Team	Expected season	Power	One-line thesis
1	Texas Tech	10.6 wins - 11-1	+22.0	The league's strongest roster and cleanest schedule path, with Will Hammond and the rebuilt defensive front determining whether top-10 quality becomes a dominant record.
2	BYU	8.8 - 9-3	+15.0	Rare QB/RB continuity and a veteran defense create the safest challenger floor, even with meaningful WR/OL and specialist turnover.
3	Kansas State	8.1 - 8-4	+9.0	Avery Johnson and the backfield are trustworthy, while a favorable schedule can lift the record above the roster's raw power rank if the rebuilt OL is functional.
4	Utah	8.0 - 8-4	+10.0	Devon Dampier keeps the ceiling high, but replacing every 2025 starting offensive lineman makes another 11-win season a much harder standard.
5	Arizona	7.6 - 8-4	+9.5	Noah Fifita and staff continuity stabilize the offense, while an NFL-heavy secondary exodus makes the 2025 defensive standard difficult to repeat.
6	Houston	7.4 - 7-5	+7.5	Conner Weigman and a strong receiver group keep Houston dangerous, but a transfer-heavy OL and rebuilt veteran defense make 10 wins a poor baseline.
7	TCU	7.4 - 7-5	+9.5	The Horned Frogs are stronger than seventh on a neutral field, but a new QB/OC pairing and a brutal late schedule widen the outcome range.
8	Oklahoma State	6.7 - 7-5	+7.0	Eric Morris and Drew Mestemaker can drive a major bounce-back, but extraordinary roster turnover makes the projection one of the least stable in the conference.
9	UCF	6.0 - 6-6	+1.5	A defined QB and manageable schedule create a bowl path even though OL/front uncertainty keeps the underlying rating below average.
10	Baylor	5.9 - 6-6	+4.0	DJ Lagway gives Baylor real offensive upside, but the Bears need a rebuilt OL and new-look defense to become more than a volatile middle-tier team.

Rank	Team	Expected season	Power	One-line thesis
11	Kansas	5.9 - 6-6	+3.5	The run game, linebacker core and special teams are useful foundations, but unresolved QB/OL roles and explosive-play defense keep the floor unstable.
12	Arizona State	5.8 - 6-6	+5.0	The Sun Devils are better than 12th in raw power, but QB uncertainty, a rebuilt OL and SOS No. 28 make six wins a reasonable midpoint.
13	Cincinnati	5.8 - 6-6	+3.0	A veteran OL and named QB1 provide an offensive floor while a defense replacing 10 starters creates one of the league's widest unit ranges.
14	Iowa State	5.1 - 5-7	-0.5	Jaylen Raynor gives a low-continuity rebuild a clear offensive centerpiece, but a new staff and an OL with no proven 2025 starter make bowl eligibility an uphill ask.
15	West Virginia	4.9 - 5-7	-1.5	Cam Cook gives the offense a real center of gravity, but unresolved QB play and only 46% defensive returning production leave little margin.
16	Colorado	4.7 - 5-7	+0.5	Julian Lewis and Brennan Marion give the offense a clearer direction, but both lines and special teams remain too unsettled for a breakout assumption.

The clearest schedule-versus-power divergence is **Kansas State**, which is sixth in underlying Big 12 power but third in expected wins. **TCU and Arizona State** move the other way: both rate higher in raw power than their projected standing because schedule difficulty and implementation risk reduce the record baseline. Texas Tech is unusual because both measures agree - the Red Raiders are clearly first either way.

4. The Title Race

Texas Tech - the conference runs through Lubbock

Texas Tech begins from a position no other Big 12 team shares. The Red Raiders are **+22.0** in Primer power, No. 8 in SP+ and project to **10.6 wins**, while the schedule avoids BYU, Utah and Kansas State. The offensive support structure is strong: Will Hammond steps into a lineup with an A- OL, a deep RB room and high-end TE/WR talent. That makes the quarterback transition much easier than replacing an established starter usually is.

The risk is concentrated on defense. Nine Red Raiders were drafted and five more signed as UDFAs, including several of the front-seven players who drove an elite 2025 unit. The defense can still be good, but expecting another top-three national baseline requires a transfer-heavy reload to recreate disruption quickly. Texas Tech does not need the defense to be identical to 2025 to win the league. It does need Hammond to keep the offense efficient enough that defensive regression does not turn favorable games into coin flips.

BYU - the safest challenger floor

BYU is the only other Big 12 team above **+10.0** in power, and the reasons are straightforward. Bear Bachmeier returns after starting all 14 games, LJ Martin remains the lead back, and the defense retains several high-end anchors while returning 69% of its production. That continuity matters in a league where several rivals are replacing quarterbacks, lines or entire defensive groups.

The ceiling question is whether the supporting cast stays contender-level. BYU must replace its top two 2025 starting receivers, settle a reshuffled OL and rebuild every major specialist role. The schedule also asks more than Texas Tech's does: Arizona arrives early, TCU and Utah are road games, and Notre Dame comes to Provo in October. BYU can win the conference without becoming a dramatically better team than the 2025 version, but it likely needs the new receivers and specialists to avoid creating narrow losses.

The four-team chase - Utah, Arizona, Kansas State and TCU

These teams are close enough in underlying quality that their structural differences matter more than a one-point power gap. **Utah** has the best quarterback of the group in Devon Dampier and a proven defensive identity, but the entire 2025 starting OL is gone. **Arizona** has Noah Fifita and offensive continuity but must replace an extraordinary amount of NFL-bound secondary talent. **Kansas State** has Avery Johnson, a useful three-back room and the best schedule path of the four, but the OL and rebuilt defensive back seven are major questions. **TCU** owns a sturdy defensive front and top-third Big 12 model strength, yet asks Jaden Craig to translate from Harvard into a new Gordon Sammis offense behind a reshuffled line.

None of the four needs to become Texas Tech's equal on a neutral field to reach the Big 12 Championship. They need to survive the compressed middle better than their peers and take advantage of schedule windows. Kansas State is the cleanest

example: it can finish ahead of a slightly stronger team simply because its path is friendlier.

5. Teams Most Likely to Be Better Than Their Record

TCU - a late schedule that can hide top-third quality

TCU is tied for third in Big 12 power at **+9.5** but only seventh in expected wins. The main reason is not a lack of talent. The Horned Frogs have a recognizable defensive front and enough model strength to be an eight-win caliber team, but the offense is installing a new system around a transfer quarterback and the schedule closes with **at Arizona, Kansas State, Utah and at Texas Tech**. A 7-5 finish would not automatically mean TCU was merely the seventh-best team in the league.

Arizona State - six wins can coexist with a better roster than the standings imply

Arizona State is ninth in Big 12 power at **+5.0** but only 12th in expected wins, with SP+ SOS No. 28 the hardest schedule in the conference. The Sun Devils still have real anchors in WR Omarion Miller, DT C.J. Fite and LB Owen Long. The problem is that QB remains unsettled, the OL is rebuilt and the secondary lost major contributors. If the new quarterback becomes merely efficient, Arizona State can look like a solid middle-tier team even if the schedule leaves the record near 6-6.

Oklahoma State - a translation bet with a wide record range

The Cowboys are a fascinating case because **+7.0** power looks nothing like the 1-11 team from 2025. Eric Morris brings an up-tempo Air Raid, Drew Mestemaker has a clear starting role, and the roster was rebuilt with more than 80 newcomers. That can produce a major jump quickly. It can also produce early cohesion problems, especially on the OL and defense. Oklahoma State's 6.7 expected wins is best viewed as a midpoint for one of the league's widest ranges rather than a precise statement about where the Cowboys belong.

6. Teams Whose Record May Run Ahead of Their Power

Kansas State - the schedule creates real standings leverage

Kansas State is the clearest Big 12 example of record outrunning raw roster rank. The Wildcats are **sixth in conference power at +9.0 but third in expected wins at 8.1**. Their schedule carries SP+ SOS No. 69 and does not include a top-30 SP+ opponent. Avery Johnson and the backfield give the offense enough stability that a merely competent rebuilt line may be sufficient to turn that path into eight or nine wins.

UCF - bowl eligibility without an above-average power profile

UCF is only **+1.5** in Primer power but projects to **6.0 wins**. The schedule is a major reason: SP+ SOS No. 65 gives the Knights a cluster of winnable games, and Alonza Barnett III provides a defined quarterback in Scott Frost's Year 2 offense. The OL and defensive front remain real concerns, so a bowl appearance should not automatically be read as evidence that UCF has become a top-half Big 12 team.

Baylor - enough offensive upside to win close middle-tier games

Baylor sits at **+4.0** in power and **5.9 expected wins**, essentially on the bowl line. DJ Lagway, Dawson Pendergrass and elite special teams give the Bears enough high-leverage strengths to steal games even if the reconstructed OL and Joe Klanderman's new defense remain uneven. That makes Baylor a candidate to finish a little better than its down-to-down consistency would suggest.

7. The Bottom of the Table

Kansas - more useful foundation than the ranking suggests

Kansas is projected 11th, but this is not an empty rebuild. The 2025 offense had top-35 EPA/play and top-25 success-rate quality, the RB room still offers Dylan Edwards/Yasin Willis explosiveness, and LB Trey Lathan anchors the defense. The problem is concentrated in high-leverage uncertainty: Cole Ballard and Isaiah Marshall are still competing at quarterback, the OL is being rebuilt, and DT Tre'von McAlpine is out for the season. Kansas has enough structure to reach six wins; the floor falls if protection and explosive-play defense do not improve.

Cincinnati - offense can keep the Bearcats afloat while the defense learns

Cincinnati has one of the lower half's clearest strengths: a veteran OL led by Evan Tengesdahl, Joe Cotton and Taran Tyo. JC French IV is the named QB1, so the offense has a more settled starting point than several nearby teams. The volatility comes on defense, where Nate Woody is installing a new 3-4 while replacing 10 starters. If the front can generate pressure before the back end is fully settled, Cincinnati can stay in the bowl race. If not, the Bearcats may need to win too many games with offense alone.

Colorado - clearer direction, still waiting on the lines

Colorado should be more functional than the 3-9 2025 team. Julian Lewis is the full-time quarterback, Brennan Marion's Go-Go offense creates a defined multi-back identity, and the skill positions have enough talent to generate offense. The question remains exactly where it was during the rebuild: both lines are unsettled, the 2025 run defense was poor and special teams grade near the bottom of the conference. Bowl eligibility is plausible if the OL and wave-rotation defensive front stabilize; five wins remains the safer center until they do.

Iowa State - a rebuild with one important piece already solved

Iowa State has only 44% returning production, a completely new staff and no proven returning 2025 starter on the OL. That is why the Cyclones sit below average in power despite a credible quarterback answer in Jaylen Raynor. Raynor gives the offense something to build around, and the defense has enough transfer talent to be functional. The season hinges on whether the staff can turn a transfer-heavy line and secondary into coherent units quickly enough to let the quarterback advantage matter.

West Virginia - Cam Cook gives the bowl chase a center of gravity

West Virginia is last in Big 12 power at **-1.5**, but the Mountaineers are not without a path. RB Cam Cook is the clearest individual strength, FB Kayden Luke adds structure to the run game, and the schedule provides several true bowl-line matchups. The problem is that quarterback remains unsettled between Michael Hawkins Jr. and Max Brown while the defense returns only 46% of its production. WVU can reach six wins if Cook keeps the offense out of obvious passing downs and the new back seven stabilizes. Another inefficient passing offense would leave almost no defensive margin.

8. Quarterback Landscape

The Big 12 has more quarterback continuity near the top than the standings volatility might suggest. That is one reason Texas Tech's new-starter question matters so much: several of its most credible challengers already know what they have at quarterback.

QB tier	Teams	Read
Established returning starters	BYU - Bear Bachmeier; Utah - Devon Dampier; Arizona - Noah Fifita; Kansas State - Avery Johnson; Houston - Conner Weigman	This is the league's strongest continuity group. Dampier has the highest individual ceiling, while Bachmeier/Johnson/Weigman give their teams proven full-season structure.
New role, but starter is defined	Texas Tech - Will Hammond; TCU - Jaden Craig; Oklahoma State - Drew Mestemaker; Baylor - DJ Lagway; Cincinnati - JC French IV; UCF - Alonza Barnett III; Colorado - Julian Lewis; Iowa State - Jaylen Raynor	The jobs are clear, but the projection range varies. Hammond has the best supporting cast; Craig must translate from Harvard; Mestemaker leads a near-total rebuild; several others are transferring into new systems or taking on larger roles.
Open competition / unresolved	Arizona State - Cutter Boley/Mikey Keene; Kansas - Cole Ballard/Isaiah Marshall; West Virginia - Michael Hawkins Jr./Max Brown	These teams carry the most direct QB uncertainty, and all three also have surrounding OL or roster questions that make a prolonged competition more costly.

Three quarterback situations deserve disproportionate attention. **Will Hammond** does not need to be the best quarterback in the conference for Texas Tech to win it; he needs to keep a strong supporting cast on schedule. **Devon Dampier** is asked to do almost the opposite: Utah's new OL may require its veteran quarterback to solve protection and creation problems early. **Jaden Craig** is the purest translation test, moving from Harvard into a new offense that also replaces major line and receiver continuity.

The middle of the conference benefits from defined roles even when the quarterback is not elite. Houston, Baylor, Cincinnati, UCF and Colorado all have clearer Week 1 plans than teams carrying open competitions. In a compressed league, avoiding quarterback ambiguity can be worth a standings place by itself.

9. Line-of-Scrimmage / Roster Continuity Themes

The Big 12 title race may be decided less by star skill talent than by which contender solves its line questions first. Several of the league's best quarterbacks sit behind reconstructed fronts, while Texas Tech's biggest replacement burden is on defense rather than offense.

Team	OL read	Defensive-front read	Why it matters
Texas Tech	A-, stable	B+, down	Four identified OL starters give Will Hammond a premium transition environment; the title question is whether a transfer-heavy front replaces a large NFL exodus without losing disruption.
BYU	B, down	B, stable	The line loses important pieces but retains Bruce Mitchell as an anchor, while the defensive core gives the Cougars a steadier foundation than most contenders.
Utah	C+, down	B, down	All five 2025 starting OL spots are open. Dampier can cover some problems, but the line rebuild is the single biggest reason Utah's floor is lower than last season's record.
Arizona	B-, down	B-, down	The OL has a few continuity anchors but remains unsettled, while the secondary/front must absorb unusually heavy NFL losses from an elite 2025 defense.
TCU	C+, down	B, stable	Center and right tackle remain unsettled, making protection central to Craig's translation; the defensive front is the roster's best stabilizer.
Kansas State	C, down	B-, down	Avery Johnson and the backs are proven, but multiple OL departures plus injuries to John Pastore and George Fitzpatrick create the team's defining risk.

Team	OL read	Defensive-front read	Why it matters
Houston	B+, up	B, down	The transfer-heavy OL has real talent but needs cohesion; the defense must replace a major veteran class after the 10-win season.

The middle has its own versions of the same problem. Oklahoma State's transfer OL is talented but health and center questions remain. Arizona State replaces first-round OT Max Iheanachor. Baylor and Kansas carry C+ line grades. Cincinnati is the notable exception: its B+ OL is one of the strongest units in the lower half and gives the Bearcats a real offensive floor. UCF, Colorado, Iowa State and West Virginia all enter with line combinations that can materially change their season if they settle quickly.

Defensively, the conference is less settled than it was a year ago. Texas Tech, Utah, Arizona, Houston and Arizona State all replace major veteran or NFL-bound production. That creates opportunity for teams with quarterback continuity to steal early games before rebuilt fronts and secondaries are fully synchronized.

10. Schedule & Swing Games

Relatively more manageable paths

- **Texas Tech - SP+ SOS No. 72:** The league favorite avoids BYU, Utah and Kansas State, and no opponent in the project rating set profiles as a true peer. That is a major championship advantage.
- **Kansas State - No. 69:** The Wildcats avoid Texas Tech, BYU and Utah, and the rated slate contains no top-30 SP+ opponent. The schedule is why Kansas State ranks higher in expected wins than in power.
- **UCF - No. 65:** The Knights have enough near-peer games to reach six wins despite a below-average power rating.
- **Utah - No. 64:** The Utes avoid Texas Tech and have three straight home games to open, giving the new OL time to stabilize before the conference grind.

Most demanding paths

- **Arizona State - SP+ SOS No. 28:** Texas A&M sits in nonconference play, and the Big 12 slate includes Texas Tech, BYU, Kansas State, UCF and Arizona around a rebuilt QB/OL structure.
- **Oklahoma State - No. 40:** Oregon is the major nonconference test, and the Cowboys then face a long run of similarly rated Big 12 teams before Texas Tech arrives.
- **TCU - No. 42:** The late schedule is the issue: Arizona, Kansas State, Utah and Texas Tech close the regular season.
- **Baylor - No. 43:** The Bears have many toss-up games and finish at BYU, Texas Tech and at Houston.

Games most likely to shape the race

- 1 **Sept. 12 - Arizona at BYU** - an immediate contender test that can establish BYU's challenger floor and reveal how much of Arizona's 2025 defensive identity survived.
- 2 **Sept. 18 - Houston at Texas Tech** - Texas Tech's conference opener and Houston's first chance to prove the 10-win season created a durable top-third Big 12 baseline.
- 3 **Oct. 3 - BYU at TCU** - a direct leverage game between the safest challenger and one of the league's strongest schedule-suppressed teams.
- 4 **Oct. 31 - Arizona at Texas Tech** - one of the few games on Texas Tech's schedule against a top-five Big 12 power profile.
- 5 **Nov. 7 - BYU at Utah** - rivalry stakes plus a direct sorting game between the league's No. 2 and No. 3 power profiles.
- 6 **Nov. 14 - Kansas State at TCU** - Kansas State's favorable schedule meets one of its most important underlying-quality tests.
- 7 **Nov. 21 - Utah at TCU** - another late contender elimination game inside TCU's brutal closing stretch.
- 8 **Nov. 26 - TCU at Texas Tech** - Thanksgiving night in Lubbock could carry direct Big 12 Championship implications if Texas Tech has not already separated.

The schedule distribution is unusually important because the Big 12's best teams do not all play one another. **Texas Tech avoids BYU, Utah and Kansas State. Kansas State avoids Texas Tech, BYU and Utah.** BYU, by contrast, plays Arizona, TCU and Utah plus Notre Dame in nonconference play. That asymmetry is a major reason projected standings should not be read as a pure power ranking.

11. Teams to Watch

Houston - was 10 wins a new baseline or a high-water mark?

Houston enters with the exact profile that can be misread if record is treated as power. The Cougars won 10 games and return Conner Weigman plus WR Amare Thomas, while Trent Walker and Makhi Hughes add offensive upside. But the 2025 efficiency profile was closer to top-40 than top-25 quality, and the OL/defense both rely heavily on newcomers. Stephon Johnson's late return strengthens receiver depth. Houston can absolutely remain an upper-half team; the question is whether it can reproduce the close-game and defensive consistency needed for another double-digit record.

Oklahoma State - the conference's purest translation experiment

Few teams in the country changed more than Oklahoma State. Eric Morris imported his Air Raid, Drew Mestemaker is the supported starter and more than 80 newcomers reshape the roster. That creates a real path from 1-11 to bowl contention because the new offense can be functional immediately. It also means September results matter more than usual: early OL health, defensive communication and special-teams stability will tell us whether the +7.0 rating is realistic or too optimistic.

Utah - can a great quarterback outrun an OL rebuild?

Utah's 2025 offense was elite by nearly every advanced measure, and Devon Dampier remains the centerpiece. The problem is that every starting OL spot changes. If the new five becomes merely average, Dampier and RB Wayshawn Parker can keep Utah in the title chase. If protection never settles, the Utes can remain a good team while sliding from 11 wins to seven or eight.

Arizona State - a defensive identity under pressure

The Sun Devils still have DT C.J. Fite, LB Owen Long and enough skill talent to reach a bowl, but the roster around them is far less settled. The QB competition, rebuilt OL and secondary turnover all arrive against the Big 12's hardest schedule by SP+ rank. Arizona State may be one of the league's clearest examples of a team that improves during the season even if the final record stays ordinary.

UCF - a schedule-assisted bowl path with real upside

UCF's +1.5 rating says the Knights are still below average on a neutral field, but Alonza Barnett III gives the offense a clear dual-threat centerpiece and the schedule offers several winnable games. The key is whether an OL replacing four veterans and a defensive front losing first-round edge talent can become functional quickly. If those units reach average, six wins can become seven or eight.

Colorado - the Julian Lewis / Go-Go experiment

Colorado is more interesting than its No. 16 projected finish suggests. Julian Lewis is the full-time quarterback and Brennan Marion's multi-back Go-Go offense gives the Buffs a clear schematic identity after a poor 2025 efficiency season. The offensive and defensive lines still cap the projection, but this is a team with enough QB/skill upside to become a difficult opponent before the standings fully reflect it.

12. Team Primer Directory

For the full roster, coaching, unit-grade, player and schedule breakdowns, open the individual team primers:

Team	Full 2026 team primer
Texas Tech	Texas Tech 2026 Preseason Primer
BYU	BYU 2026 Preseason Primer
Kansas State	Kansas State 2026 Preseason Primer
Utah	Utah 2026 Preseason Primer
Arizona	Arizona 2026 Preseason Primer
Houston	Houston 2026 Preseason Primer
TCU	TCU 2026 Preseason Primer
Oklahoma State	Oklahoma State 2026 Preseason Primer
UCF	UCF 2026 Preseason Primer
Baylor	Baylor 2026 Preseason Primer
Kansas	Kansas 2026 Preseason Primer
Arizona State	Arizona State 2026 Preseason Primer
Cincinnati	Cincinnati 2026 Preseason Primer
Iowa State	Iowa State 2026 Preseason Primer
West Virginia	West Virginia 2026 Preseason Primer
Colorado	Colorado 2026 Preseason Primer

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